

The Secret of the Casket

On her 75th birthday, Suman distributed her wealth among her four sons and announced that she would spend three months of the year with each son, in turn.

The **arrangement** worked well **for a while** and then the old woman found that the welcome she received at each son's house was becoming less and less **cordial**. Finally, she began to feel positively **unwanted**. Now she **saw** her sons in **their true colours**. Money meant everything to them; people came second.



One day, Suman's friend, Manju, came to see her. Manju was **distressed** to find her friend in such an unhappy **state** and advised her on what she should do. Afterwards, Manju **tearfully embraced** her friend and left.

A few days later, towards sundown, Suman went out without telling anyone where she was going and returned an hour later, her clothes covered in mud.

"Where did you go?" asked her son, and then seeing that she was holding a small **ornamental** chest, hurried to her, his **gaze riveted on** the **casket**.

"What is that?"

"Something that could change all our lives for the better, in different ways," said his mother.

"What does it contain?"

"You'll find out when I'm dead and gone."

The young man lost no time in informing his brothers about the casket.

"It is obvious she has not given us all her wealth," said the eldest. "She must have kept back some of her more valuable gems. God alone knows how many caskets the **wily** woman has **buried**."

They questioned their mother but she refused to tell what the casket contained, or even if there were more caskets hidden elsewhere. Many a time, the brothers tried to open the casket in her absence but it was securely locked and they could never find the key.

But now Suman no longer felt unwanted. Her sons and daughters-in-law **fussed over** her and went out of their way to make her feel welcome. In fact, now each son tried to **persuade** her to stay longer than the three months, but she never extended her stay, not wishing to show a preference for any son.

She **passed away** in her sleep, a few days before her 84th birthday. Her friend, Manju, came for the **funeral rites** and before departing handed over a key to the dead woman's eldest son in the presence of his brothers.

"This is the key to the casket," she said and left.

The sons and their wives **hurried** to the old woman's **chamber** in great excitement. This was the day they had been waiting for, for weeks and months and years. They **bolted** the door from the inside and **huddled** around the casket. With **trembling** hands, the oldest brother fitted the key into the lock and turned it.

It opened with a click. The man **flicked** open the **lid** and then they all **stared** with disbelief at the contents: ordinary **pebbles**.

"The gems might be below," said the oldest brother and **frantically** overturned the contents.

All they found was a note from their mother. It read:

"Great disappointment follows great **greed**."

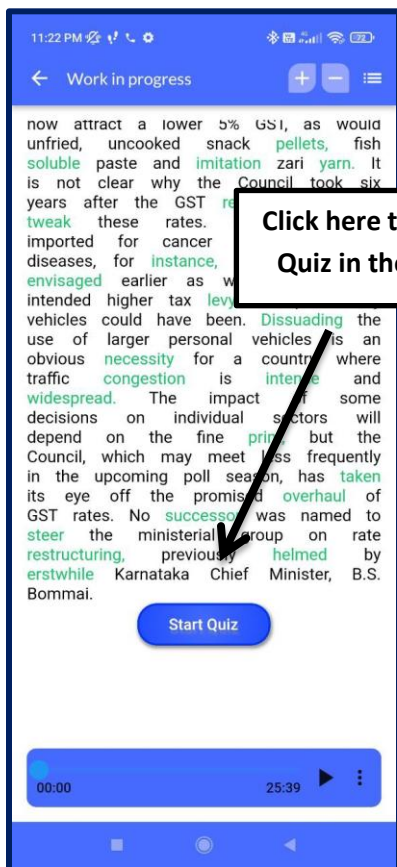
[Audio of this story is available on the App & Website of the English Madhyam.](#)

Vocabulary

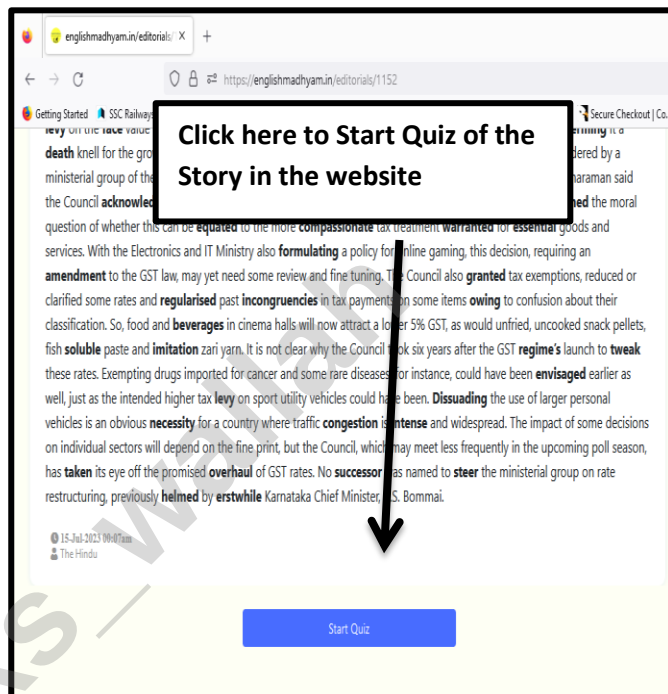
1. **Arrangement** (noun) – plan, agreement, setup, scheme, structure – व्यवस्था
2. **For a while** (phrase) – temporarily, for some time, briefly, for a short period, momentarily – कुछ समय के लिए
3. **Cordial** (adjective) – warm, friendly, affectionate, genial, sincere – सौहार्दपूर्ण
4. **Unwanted** (adjective) – rejected, unwelcome, disliked, neglected, shunned – अवांछित
5. **See someone's in true colour** (phrase) – understand someone's real nature, see reality, perceive truth, unmask, reveal character – असली रूप देखना
6. **Distressed** (adjective) – troubled, upset, anguished, pained, worried – दुखी
7. **State** (noun) – condition, situation, position, shape, plight – स्थिति
8. **Tearfully** (adverb) – emotionally, weepingly, sorrowfully, sadly, crying – आँसुओं के साथ
9. **Embrace** (verb) – hug, hold, clasp, cuddle, squeeze – गले लगाना
10. **Ornamental** (adjective) – decorative, fancy, embellished, adorned, showy – सजावटी
11. **Gaze** (noun) – stare, look, glance, view, peep – टकटकी
12. **Rivet** (on) (verb) – fixate, focus, fasten, grip, attach – ध्यान केंद्रित करना
13. **Casket** (noun) – chest, box, container, coffer, case – संदूक
14. **Wily** (adjective) – cunning, clever, crafty, shrewd, sly – चालाक
15. **Bury** (verb) – hide, inter, conceal, entomb, plant – दफनाना
16. **Fuss over** (phrasal verb) – pamper, coddle, indulge, show excessive care, dote – ज़्यादा ध्यान देना
17. **Persuade** (verb) – convince, influence, urge, coax, sway – समझाना
18. **Pass away** (phrasal verb) – die, expire, depart, perish, succumb – निधन होना
19. **Funeral** (adjective) – burial-related, memorial, mourning, obsequial, last-rites – अंतिम संस्कार से संबंधित
20. **Rite** (noun) – ritual, ceremony, observance, tradition, practice – रस्म
21. **Hurry** (verb) – rush, dash, race, hasten, scramble – जल्दी करना
22. **Chamber** (noun) – room, hall, compartment, enclosure, space – कक्ष

23. **Bolt** (verb) – lock, latch, secure, fasten, bar
– कुंडी लगाना
24. **Huddle** (verb) – crowd, gather, cluster,
group, bunch – झुंड बनाना
25. **Trembling** (adjective) – shaking, shivering,
quivering, jittery, unsteady – कांपता हुआ
26. **Flick** (verb) – snap, flip, jerk, twitch, switch
– झटके से खोलना
27. **Lid** (noun) – cover, cap, top, closure, flap –
ढक्कन
28. **Stare** (at) (verb) – gaze, look fixedly, glare,
peer, gawk – घूरना
29. **Pebble** (noun) – stone, rock, gravel, chip,
cobble – कंकड़
30. **Frantically** (adverb) – desperately, wildly,
hurriedly, hysterically, feverishly – बेकाबू
होकर
31. **Greed** (noun) – avarice, selfishness,
gluttony, materialism, craving – लालच

Practice Exercise



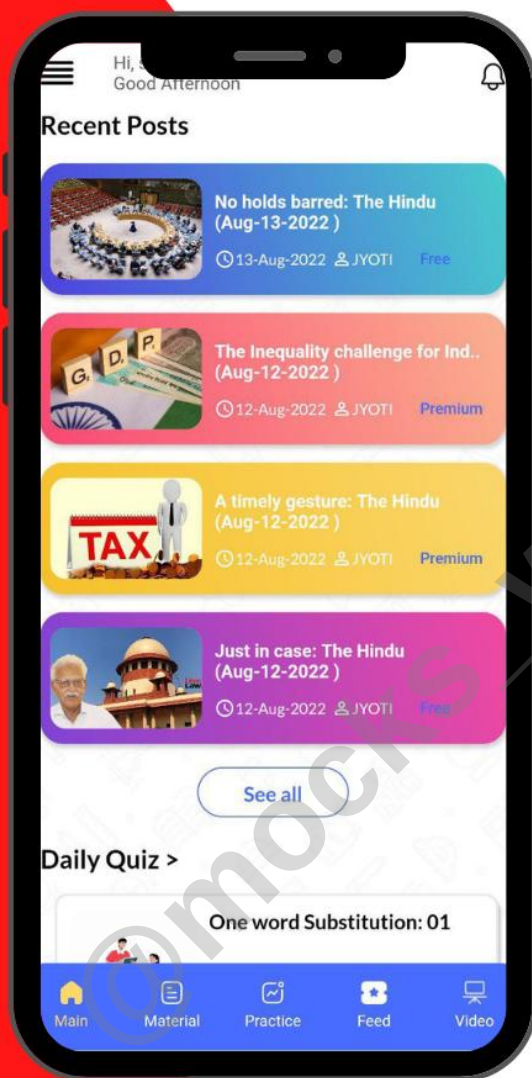
Click here to Start Quiz in the App



Click here to Start Quiz of the Story in the website

[Click here to download App](#)

[Click here to visit website](#)



Learn Vocabulary Through Reading Articles

English Madhyam